Formulating Geographic Headings

H 690

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A. Background

Headings for geographic names fall into two categories: (1) names of political jurisdictions, and (2) non-jurisdictional geographic names. Headings in the first category are established according to descriptive cataloging conventions with authority records that reside in the name authority file. Headings in the second category are established according to guidelines in this

instruction sheet with authority records that reside in the subject authority file. Headings for entities having geographic extent, including certain types of engineering constructions, are treated as geographic headings. The following is a representative list of such entities:

- Archaeological sites, historic sites, etc.
- Areas and regions (when not free-floating)
- Canals
- Dams
- Extinct cities (pre-1500)
- Farms, ranches, gardens
- Forests, grasslands, etc.
- Geographic features (for example, caves, deserts, non-jurisdictional islands, lakes, mountains, ocean currents, plains, rivers, seas, steppes, undersea features)
- Geologic basins, geologic formations, etc.
- Mines
- Parks, reserves, refuges, recreation areas, etc.
- Reservoirs
- Roads, streets, trails
- Valleys

Consult H 405 for further guidance on what entities belong in the name authority file vs. the subject authority file.

This instruction sheet provides guidelines for formulating the substantive portion of non-jurisdictional geographic names established as subject headings. For procedures for qualifying geographic names, see H 810.

Note: When a new country is formed or a country changes its name, LC coordinates with the Board on Geographic Names, which gets its information from the State Department. Please refrain from sending proposals or creating authority records that include the new country name until LC has created the name authority record and determined the appropriate LCSH treatment.

B. Recent revisions

2025-03: Clarified use of BGN. Updated template.

C. Definitions

BGN: The United States Board on Geographic Names, a Federal body created in 1890 and established in its present form by Public Law in 1947 to maintain uniform geographic name usage throughout the Federal Government.

GeoNames: A global geographical database based in Switzerland with a wiki style edit interface. It is not the same as GNS or GNIS, and it is not a preferred source for geographic information.

GNIS: The Geographic Names Information System, a database maintained by the U.S. Geological Survey. The GNIS contains the domestic place names approved by the BGN. It is not the same as GeoNames.

GNS: The Geographic Names Server, a database maintained by the National Geospatial-Intelligence Agency. The GNS contains the foreign place names approved by the BGN. A previous name for this database was GeoNet. It is not the same as GeoNames.

D. Form of heading

D.1. Sources of approved names

Obtain the approved form of name from the following required reference sources, when possible.

D.1.a. Names of the United States

For names of the United States, the Geographic Names Information System (GNIS) is available on the Internet. GNIS may be accessed and queried at <https://edits.nationalmap.gov/apps/gaz-domestic/public/search/names>.

Always use the approved name from GNIS as the basis for the heading in LCSH.

Note: Not all features mentioned in the Background statement are found in GNIS. For features that are not in GNIS, follow the instructions in sections D.2 and D.3 below.

D.1.b. Foreign names other than those of New Zealand

For foreign geographic names other than those of New Zealand, the Geographic Names Server (GNS) is available on the Internet. GNS may be accessed and queried at <https://geonames.nga.mil/geonames/GeographicNamesSearch/>.

Use names from GNS as the basis for LCSH headings in the following order of preference:

1. Conventional name, if it exists
2. Approved name
3. If GNS gives more than one approved name for a geographic feature, use the approved name that is in English.

Note: Not all features mentioned in the Background statement are found in GNS. For features that are not in GNS, follow the instructions in sections D.2 and D.3 below.

D.1.c. Names of New Zealand

For names of New Zealand, prefer the form found the New Zealand Gazetteer. The Gazetteer may be accessed and queried on the Internet at <https://gazetteer.linz.govt.nz/>.

To find Māori place names with macrons, download this .csv file from the Gazetteer: <https://gazetteer.linz.govt.nz/maori_names.csv>.

D.2. Additional authority research

Although the BGN decision, when it is obtained, is preferred over any other name forms for all names other than those of New Zealand, catalogers should also consult other standard authorities. Recommended resources for geographic names include *Merriam-Webster's Geographical Dictionary*, *Columbia Gazetteer of the World*, *National Gazetteer of the United States of America*, national gazetteers issued by the country where the feature is located, standard encyclopedias, atlases, titles in the database, etc. This additional authority work is required for the following reasons:

- The BGN decision may not in itself be sufficient to determine if name conflicts exist and further qualification of the heading is necessary.
- In cases of conflict, research can confirm that the BGN decision does in fact refer to the same place discussed in the work being cataloged.
- For geographic names in non-English-speaking countries, reference sources may aid in the translation of generic terms.
- Variant forms of the geographic name found in reference sources are useful as UF references in addition to the variants provided by BGN.
- Not all types of geographic features are included in the BGN database. Examples of features that are not included are: roads, highways, administrative, or cultural features. In 2021, some items were removed from GNIS that had previously been included: airport, bridge, building, cemetery, church, dam, forest, harbor, hospital, mine, oilfield, park, post office, reserve, school, tower, trail, tunnel, and well. These are now considered “administrative” and therefore fall into the list of features that are not included in BGN.

Cite the works consulted in 670 fields in the authority record, following the conventions for citation of sources described in H 203. Record in a $b subfield of each 670 field any data that conflicts with, or supplements, the BGN decision. Record any data showing that the name under consideration conflicts with other names. This serves to justify the form of the qualifier constructed in accordance with H 810.

D.3. Selecting the form of name

D.3.a. The BGN decision

If the BGN decision has been obtained, favor it over any other name forms obtained from other sources. (See sec. D.1.b for guidance on the form of name.) Adjust it or choose another name form when necessary to conform with the "Additional guidelines" (sec. D.3.b) provided below.

If no BGN decision is obtained, select the form of name found to be in predominant usage in the reference sources that were consulted.

D.3.b. Additional guidelines

D.3.b.i. English vs. vernacular form

Select the English form of the name whenever possible.

Examples:

Note: These examples omit geographic qualifiers. For rules for qualification, see H 810.

Vernacular form	English form
Passo del San Gottardo	Saint Gottard Pass
Fujiyama	Mount Fuji
Øresund	The Sound
Peipsi järv	Lake Peipus

If no English form is found, construct an English heading by translating the generic term into English. If, in the case of certain inflected languages, the resulting construction is grammatically awkward, use the noun form of the proper name in the nominative case, rather than either the adjectival form or the noun form in the genitive case. In such situations, provide UF references from the pure vernacular forms, as specified in sec. E.1, below.

Examples:

151 ## $a Strážov Mountains (Slovakia)

451 ## $a Strážovská hornatina (Slovakia)

451 ## $a Strážovské vrchy (Slovakia)

[*not* 151 ## $a Strážovská Mountains (Slovakia) or 151 ## $a Strážovské Mountains (Slovakia)]

151 ## $a Gauja River (Latvia and Estonia)

451 ## $a Gaujas upe (Latvia and Estonia)

[*not* 151 ## $a Gaujas River (Latvia and Estonia)]

D.3.b.ii. When to use the vernacular form

Select the vernacular form if the generic term is an integral part of the name and cannot be separated from the distinctive portion. For example, the Finnish name Kilpisjärvi includes the generic "järvi", meaning lake. The approved name for this feature will be ***Kilpisjärvi (Finland and Sweden)***.

Use the vernacular form when establishing parks, reserves, gardens, trails, streets, and roads. See H 1925 for specific instructions for parks, reserves, gardens, and trails; see H 2098 for streets and roads.

Also use the vernacular if the entity in question is best known in the English-speaking world by its vernacular name, for example, ***Rio Grande***; ***Blanc, Mont (France and Italy)***.

Use English-language gazetteers and reference sources to determine whether an entity is known in its vernacular form in the English-speaking world. If a vernacular form is used and it includes the generic term for the feature, do not add the English generic term to the heading. For example, ***Tien Shan*** is a conventional name which includes the Chinese term for mountains. Do not add "Mountains" to the heading.

D.3.b.iii. Arrangement of elements appearing in the name

If necessary, rearrange the elements of the name so that the distinctive portion of the name occurs in the initial position.

D.3.b.iii.1. Names in English

For entities in English-speaking countries, and for entities that have a conventional English name, invert the heading if necessary to put the distinctive portion of the name in the initial position.

Examples:

Note: These examples omit geographic qualifiers. For rules for qualification, see H 810.

English name	Inverted form
Firth of Forth	Forth, Firth of
Lake Erie	Erie, Lake
Mount Abbot	Abbot, Mount
River Wye	Wye, River
Strait of Gibraltar	Gibraltar, Strait of

D.3.b.iii.2. Names in foreign languages

Translate the generic part of the name and rearrange the elements to put the distinctive portion of the name in the initial position. Since the resulting heading is not inverted, do not put a comma between the elements.

Examples:

Vernacular form	Final form of heading
Río Jiloca	**Jiloca River (Spain)**
Bahía Mazarredo	**Mazarredo Bay (Chile)**

D.3.b.iv. Abbreviations

Spell out in full all words in the substantive portion of the name. For provisions on the use of abbreviations in qualifiers, see H 810.

Example:

151 ## $a Saint Andrew Sound (Ga.)

[*not* 151 ## $a St. Andrew Sound (Ga.)]

D.3.b.v. Initial articles

Anglicize names of geographic features that are located in non-English-speaking countries and that begin with an article by dropping the initial article and including a generic term in English describing the feature. Retain initial articles for non-English names in English-speaking countries. For English names beginning with the word “The” as an integral part of the name, retain “The” and invert the name.

Examples:

Name of entity	Type of feature	Final form of heading
La Huasteca	[a region in Mexico]	**Huasteca Region (Mexico)**
Les Cévennes	[mountains in France]	**Cévennes Mountains (France)**
Los Olmos Creek	[a stream in Texas]	**Los Olmos Creek (Tex.)**
The Fens	[a region in England]	**Fens, The (England)**
The Sound	[conventional English name for a sound between Denmark and Sweden]	**Sound, The (Denmark and Sweden)**

D.3.b.vi. Transliteration

As a general rule, transliterate geographic names in non-roman scripts by means of LC transliteration tables. If BGN provides a romanized form in conflict with LC's policy for the romanization of a particular script, convert the name to the LC form. However, if it is clear that a non-LC-romanized form is more commonly used in English-language reference sources, establish the heading using that form, and add a 451 field with the LC-romanized form.

Note: During 1999 the Library of Congress changed a limited number of name and subject headings that contain names of Chinese provinces and major cities from conventional to pinyin romanized forms. In October 2000 the Library discontinued use of the Wade-Giles system of romanization of Chinese in favor of pinyin in name and subject headings except for geographic names of Taiwan, which continued to use Wade-Giles. In May 2012 the Library determined that pinyin romanization will now be used for geographic name and subject headings for places in Taiwan. This decision follows the 2010 decision of the U.S. Board on Geographic Names, which now also uses pinyin romanization for places in Taiwan.

D.3.b.vii. Conflicts

Conflicts involving geographic names may be resolved by designating the category of the feature in the parenthetical qualifier following a colon (see H 810) or by incorporating the generic term for the feature into the name itself. Prefer the latter method if it will resolve the conflict without causing redundancy.

Exception: For named regions that conflict with names of cities, include the term “Region” in the qualifier (cf. H 760, sec. 1.e.(2)).

Examples:

Situation	Final form of heading
Skovfjorden is the name of a fjord and of a marine channel in Greenland.	**Skovfjorden (Greenland : Fjord)**
Madura is the name of an island and of several cities in Indonesia.	**Madura Island (Indonesia)** [*not* Madura (Indonesia : Island)]
Bresse is the name of a region in France and the name of a French town.	**Bresse (France : Region)**

D.3.b.viii. Capitalization

When formulating names or references, use the appropriate current rules of capitalization for the language in question (see Appendix B of this manual).

For English forms of place names, capitalize all nouns and adjectives that are essential parts of the name. For example, in the heading ***Tatar Strait (Russia)***, the word "Strait" is capitalized since the heading is in English. However, in the UF reference from the vernacular form, ***Tatarskiĭ proliv (Russia)***, the word "proliv" is lowercased in accordance with Russian capitalization rules.

E. References

E.1. Used For references

Add Used For (UF) references for the following alternative forms of names.

- Provide UF references for variant name forms supplied by BGN or found in other authorities, and their LC romanized equivalents, if applicable.
- Provide a UF reference for the straight form of the name if the heading is established in inverted form.
- Provide a UF reference for the name in the vernacular if the name is translated into English or if a conventional English form is adopted. In this reference, a generic term may appear in the initial position.
- Provide UF references for other pertinent foreign language forms, for example, forms in other official languages of the country where the feature is located, or the form in the language of countries that previously controlled the feature. Do not add UF references for foreign language forms if the languages are not pertinent to the feature.
- Provide a UF reference for the English form of the name, if meaningful, if the selected name is in the vernacular.
- Provide UF references for abbreviated forms, if the name commonly occurs with an abbreviated term in the initial position.
- Provide UF references for alternative forms after the decision has been reached to include or delete the initial article.
- Provide a UF reference for the BGN romanized form if it differs from the LC romanized form and has been supplied as a variant by BGN.

E.2. Broader term references

E.2.a. General rule

Add up to three broader term (BT) references containing the generic heading for the type of feature, structure, etc., subdivided by country, etc. For features in more than three countries or

first order political divisions of the United States, Canada, and Great Britain, use an appropriate broader geographic name as the subdivision.

References are made for some types of entities, such as parks, archaeological sites, early cities, etc., according to pattern provisions. These patterns are described in individual instruction sheets in this manual.

E.2.b. Named groups as broader terms

Add a BT containing the named group to which an individual feature belongs, if appropriate and if the heading already exists, for example, an individual peak in a mountain range or an individual lake in a group of lakes, such as ***Great Lakes (North America)*** or ***Finger Lakes (N.Y.)***.

Do not establish headings for larger groups only to make this kind of reference. Make this reference from the smallest applicable named group. Do not add a BT reference for the name of a region in which a feature is located.

Example:

```
151 ## $a Black Mountains (N.C.)
551 ## $w g $a Blue Ridge Mountains
[not 551 ## $w g $a Appalachian Mountains]
```

F. Model for heading and references

The above provisions may be summarized as follows:

Model:

```
151 ## $a [distinctive name] [generic term] ([geographic qualifier])
451 ## $a [alternate name(s)] ([geographic qualifier])
550 ## $w g $a [type of feature, structure, etc.] $z [country or first order
      division]
551 ## $w g $a [name of group] ([geographic qualifier])
```

G. Extended examples

Note: The following examples illustrate complete headings, including the proper forms of qualifiers. For rules for qualification, see H 810.

```
151 ## $a Margeride Mountains (France)
451 ## $a Montagnes de la Margeride (France)
551 ## $w g $a Massif Central (France)
```

```
550 ## $w g $a Mountains $z France

151 ## $a Ejón Hill (Colombia)
451 ## $a Cerrejón (Colombia)
451 ## $a El Cerrejón (Colombia)
451 ## $a Cerro Ejón (Colombia)
550 ## $w g $a Mountains $z Colombia

151 ## $a El Capitan (Calif.)
451 ## $a Capitan (Calif.)
550 ## $w g $a Mountains $z California
551 ## $w g $a Sierra Nevada (Calif. and Nev.)

151 ## $a Erzgebirge (Czech Republic and Germany)
451 ## $a Kruše hory (Czech Republic and Germany)
451 ## $a Krušnohoří (Czech Republic and Germany)
451 ## $a Ore Mountains (Czech Republic and Germany)
550 ## $w g $a Mountains $z Czech Republic
550 ## $w g $a Mountains $z Germany

151 ## $a Forth, Firth of (Scotland)
451 ## $a Bodotria (Scotland)
451 ## $a Firth of Forth (Scotland)
451 ## $a Forth Estuary (Scotland)
451 ## $a Forth, River, Estuary (Scotland)
550 ## $w g $a Estuaries $z Scotland

151 ## $a Fuji, Mount (Japan)
451 ## $a Fuji san (Japan)
451 ## $a Fuji yama (Japan)
451 ## $a Fujiyama (Japan)
451 ## $a Mount Fuji (Japan)
451 ## $a Suji Mountain (Japan)
550 ## $w g $a Mountains $z Japan
550 ## $w g $a Volcanoes $z Japan
```

151 ## $a Peipus, Lake (Estonia and Russia)
451 ## $a Chudskoe ozero (Estonia and Russia)
451 ## $a Chudskoye ozero (Estonia and Russia)
451 ## $a Lake Peipus (Estonia and Russia)
451 ## $a Peipsi järv (Estonia and Russia)
550 ## $w g $a Lakes $z Estonia
550 ## $w g $a Lakes $z Russia (Federation)

151 ## $a Rio de la Plata (Argentina and Uruguay)
451 ## $a Plate River (Argentina and Uruguay)
451 ## $a Plata, Rio de la (Argentina and Uruguay)
550 ## $w g $a Estuaries $z Argentina
550 ## $w g $a Estuaries $z Uruguay

151 ## $a Suiattle River (Wash.)
451 ## $a Miner's Creek (Snohomish County and Skagit County, Wash.)
550 ## $w g $a Rivers $z Washington (State)

151 ## $a Saint Gotthard Pass (Switzerland)
451 ## $a Gotthard Pass (Switzerland)
451 ## $a Pass of Saint Gotthard (Switzerland)
451 ## $a Passo del San Gottardo (Switzerland)
451 ## $a Saint Gothard Pass (Switzerland)
451 ## $a Sankt Gotthardpass (Switzerland)
451 ## $a St. Gotthard Pass (Switzerland)
550 ## $w g $a Mountain passes $z Switzerland

151 ## $a Sound, The (Denmark and Sweden)
451 ## $a Øresund (Denmark and Sweden)
451 ## $a Sundet (Denmark and Sweden)
451 ## $a The Sound (Denmark and Sweden)
550 ## $w g $a Sounds (Geomorphology) $z Denmark
550 ## $w g $a Sounds (Geomorphology) $z Sweden

151 ## $a Wye, River (Wales and England)
451 ## $a River Wye (Wales and England)

```
550 ## $w g $a Rivers $z England
550 ## $w g $a Rivers $z Wales

151 ## $a Yellow River (China)
451 ## $a Hoang Ho (China)
451 ## $a Huang He (China)
451 ## $a Huang Ho (China)
451 ## $a Hwang Ho (China)
550 ## $w g $a Rivers $z China
```

Revision history

2025-03: Clarified use of BGN. Updated template.

2025-02: Updated instruction sheet to new template. Corrected metadata properties. Added definitions. Updated examples.